



A Founder's Field Guide

How to Get Into Y Combinator

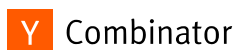
A methodical, reverse-engineered guide to
the application and the interview



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Co-founder & CTO of Escape · YC W23

Written by the co-founder & CTO of  ESCAPE



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How to Get Into Y Combinator — First Edition.

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INTRODUCTION

Who am I?

I'm Antoine Carossio, co-founder and CTO of Escape, the AI-native offensive security platform. I went through Y Combinator in the **W23** batch and took Escape from zero to 100+ enterprise customers and an **\$18M Series A** led by Balderton Capital. Before Escape I was an AI researcher at Apple and a penetration tester for the French Ministry for the Armed Forces; I hold a double master's from École Polytechnique and HEC Paris, speak on AI and cybersecurity at RSA, Black Hat, and DEF CON, and was named to the Forbes 30 Under 30. (There's a fuller bio at the back of the book.)

Since my own batch, I've mentored quite a few startups that got into YC. This guide is constantly evolving: I'm writing it as the most recent and accurate compilation of the remarks, patterns, and lessons I've noticed about getting admitted. It's a rigorous, methodical approach.

I also treat YC the way I've treated every other competitive selection process I've been through. I'm used to high-stakes entrance exams, having passed some of the most selective ones in France. YC is just another one: a process you can reverse-engineer and prepare for.

Context for non-French readers. France selects its top students through *concours*: brutal, standardized entrance exams that gate admission to its elite *grandes écoles*. The two I went through are among the most competitive in the world: École Polytechnique (the count-

ry's foremost engineering school, founded 1794, historically run by the Ministry of Defence) and HEC Paris (its leading business school). The relevant point isn't the prestige, it's that these are exams with discernible patterns, and YC's selection is no different.

Why go to YC?

Every young entrepreneur tells me about “their idea” and asks whether I “can give feedback on their solution.” They’ve been building it for weeks or months and they’re looking for “people to test it and give feedback.” I genuinely tell them I can’t help with that: that helping would be dishonest and could even kill their project. The reason is that I am not their persona (except, obviously, when I am, which is a completely different situation).

That’s the default framing of almost everyone junior starting a company. It’s the framing you must avoid: in my experience, it gets applications rejected almost every time.

Product-market fit: the only goal of an entrepreneur is to solve a problem (or create value) for a specific category of person (the “persona”) inside a specific category of company (the “ICP”). To that end, they offer a solution (the product or service) that the customer is willing to pay for (the ACV). This is the “business model.” You must ensure that the number of personas within your ICP, multiplied by the ACV, is large enough to make a lot of money (the market size).

The execution plan (how you conquer the market) implies some investment (costs) and growth (new revenue). This is the “business plan.” In the short term, you must ensure your solution is better than the competition (differentiation); in the long term, you must ensure it stays that way (defensibility). This is what YC summarizes in its motto: “Build something people want.”

The YC batch is three months:

- The first two months are dedicated to changing your mindset by forcing you to expose yourself to customers and iterate fast toward product-market fit.
- The last month is dedicated to the roadshow: putting you in front of the top-tier investors in the world.

YC will do nothing in your place. They will simply move you from being a student with an idea to being an entrepreneur singularly focused on finding PMF.

Do I need revenue to apply?

No. You need to show that you understand and are actively working with your persona. It doesn't have to be the top-tier persona in the Bay Area; it can be a handful of personas in companies similar to the ones you'd find in the Bay. What matters more is demonstrating your methodology for building a startup and finding PMF: showing that you already have the right mindset (see above) and that you're ready to apply it in the Bay.

PART I

THE WRITTEN
APPLICATION

1

APPLY NOW — AND AT EVERY BATCH

This is anecdotal (based on what I've seen, not on any official YC policy), but in my experience, applying at every batch is not penalizing. The YC team appears to be good at tracking the progress of projects across applications and comparing your previous one with the new one. Specifically, if they gave you advice (say you made it to the interview but were rejected), my impression is that they check whether you acted on it. Treat this as a working assumption, not a rule: write each application as if the reviewer remembers the last one, and show what changed.

THE PMF FRAMEWORK — ANSWER ANY QUESTION THE RIGHT WAY

The strategy is always the same:

1. **Problem.** Show that your conversations with customers surfaced a real, specific problem you're solving (product and business model).
2. **Team / founder-market fit.** Show why *you*, specifically, are the right people to solve *this* problem: relevant background, unfair insight, or unusual obsession. YC weights the team almost as heavily as the idea, sometimes more, because the idea will change and the team won't. Don't bury this; make it an explicit pillar.
3. **Market.** Show how big the upside is if you solve it (business plan).
4. **Why YC / why SF.** Show why YC and San Francisco are the obvious way to solve it (capital, network, density of customers and talent).
5. **Ambition with your feet on the ground.** Show that you're extremely ambitious but grounded in reality.

On top of these, YC looks hard at **traction and momentum**, and momentum matters more than absolute numbers. “We have \$5k MRR” says less than “we went from 0 to \$5k MRR in three weeks, growing 30% week over week.” If you have users, revenue, or a fast build-meas-

ure-learn loop, lead with the *rate of change*. If you have no numbers yet, your traction *is* your customer learning velocity: how many people you've talked to, what you learned, and how fast you're iterating.

If you're ever in doubt or feel trapped, whatever the question, go back to the customer (or to a specific customer conversation) and build a logical line of reasoning that answers the question starting from something connected to the customer. But returning to the customer is a way to *reason*, not a way to *dodge*: still answer the actual question that was asked (see the interview section).

3

MAKE IT UNDERSTANDABLE IN TWO MINUTES — BUT DEEP

Answer every long-text question the same way:

- A short, 1–2 sentence TL;DR that directly answers the question.
- Then a longer development that says the same thing with the relevant details.

Put yourself in the head of an examiner who reviews hundreds or thousands of applications a month. This format lets them grasp your project at a glance and dig into the details only if they want to.

SPECIFICITY IS THE UNIVERSAL TELL

If you remember one thing, remember this: vague founders lose, specific founders win. Specificity is the single strongest signal that you're actually doing the work, and its absence is the fastest way to look like every other rejected applicant.

"We talked to customers and there's strong demand" is worthless; it's what everyone writes. Compare: "I spoke to 14 heads of security; 9 said they currently solve this with a spreadsheet and a contractor; 2 are already paying us \$X/month." The second version proves the problem, the persona, the willingness to pay, and your work ethic in one sentence. Every pillar of the framework above gets sharper when you replace adjectives ("huge market," "strong traction," "great team") with concrete numbers, names, and facts. When in doubt, add a specific.

GET RECOMMENDATIONS

Being recommended seems to be a small plus, not a requirement. But if you get recommendations, optimize for *quality*, not volume. The official form (below) explicitly asks how well the recommender knows you and rates you on a strength scale, so the team can read straight through a pile of weak “worth a look” recs from people who barely know you. One strong recommendation from someone who has actually worked with you and rates you a 3 or 4 beats five lukewarm ones. Spend your effort getting a couple of credible, close, enthusiastic alumni to vouch for you specifically.

Recommendations can be linked to your application even after the deadline.

Recommend a Startup

One founder's email address (used to apply to YC):

Optional: One founder's Hacker News username (usernames are case-sensitive):

Strength:

-1: Avoid them.

0: I'm neutral about them.

1: They're worth a look.

2: You should definitely interview them.

3: They're likely to be in the top half of their batch.

4: They're likely to be in the top 10% of their batch.

How do you know the applicant?

I don't really know this person.

I know this person but not well.

I'm friends with this person.

I've worked with this person.

I'm related to this person.

I'm their Startup School advisor.

Did the applicant ask you for this recommendation?

Yes

No

Comments (make sure to tell us how you know the founder(s)):

PART II



THE INTERVIEW

6

MAP THE QUESTION SPACE — DON'T MEMORIZE

The interview is short (around 10 minutes), fast, and highly repetitive: nearly every question is probing the same things (the pillars of the PMF framework above). So map the space. Feed your application to ChatGPT or Claude and have it generate the likely questions and the hardest follow-ups, then make sure you genuinely *know* the answer to each: the numbers, the customer stories, the reasoning.

The trap is over-rehearsing. The interview is deliberately designed to break scripted answers, and partners can hear a memorized pitch instantly; it reads as a red flag, not preparation. Worse, a rehearsed founder answers the question they prepared instead of the one they were asked. So use the prep to find the *gaps in your knowledge*, not to produce canned lines. What's actually being tested is whether you can think and speak about your own business faster and more specifically than anyone else in the room, and you can only do that if you know it cold, not if you've memorized a paragraph.

MAKE SURE YOU UNDERSTAND THE QUESTION

When necessary, don't hesitate to say things like:

- “It seems like you want to know whether...”
- “To make sure I'm relevant, can you confirm you're asking about...?”

(See Chris Voss, *Never Split the Difference*.)

WHEN TRAPPED, RETURN TO THE CUSTOMER

Leave nothing to chance:

- Whatever happens, come back to the pillars above.
- If you feel trapped, return to the customer, and above all, don't rush into a weak answer (see the PMF framework above).
- Reasoning from the customer keeps your *content* sound, but it won't save you from *behavioral* red flags. You can still hurt yourself by dodging a direct question, talking over your cofounder, freezing, or hiding bad numbers. So: answer the actual question directly and fast, *then* anchor it in the customer. The framework is your compass, not a place to hide.

ANY QUESTIONS?

This guide will keep evolving as I notice new patterns. If it helped, or if you want a second pair of eyes on your application, reach out — I read every message, and I've helped a number of founders sharpen the exact things this book covers.

Contact me on LinkedIn: [linkedin.com/in/acarossio](https://www.linkedin.com/in/acarossio), or find more of my writing on AI and security at caross.io.

ABOUT THE AUTHOR



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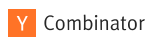
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ABOUT ESCAPE



Escape is the AI-native offensive security platform. Its agents continuously discover, test, and fix vulnerabilities directly inside engineering workflows — attack-surface management, business-logic-aware DAST, and continuous AI pentesting. Founded in 2020 and a member of the YC W23 batch, Escape raised an \$18M Series A led by Balderton Capital (with Uncorrelated Ventures, IRIS, and Y Combinator) and is trusted by 2,000+ security teams worldwide.

escape.tech



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Most applications are rejected for the same reasons. This guide breaks the written application and the 10-minute interview down into a single repeatable framework — product-market fit reasoning — and shows, concretely, how to answer any question the right way. It is written by a founder who went through W23 and has since coached startups into the batch.

- › The PMF framework: the five pillars behind every answer
- › Why specificity is the universal tell — and how to add it
- › How to prepare for the interview without over-rehearsing
- › Recommendations, momentum, and applying every batch



Antoine Carossio — Antoine Carossio is the co-founder & CTO of Escape (YC W23, \$18M Series A), a Forbes 30 Under 30 honoree, and a speaker on AI & cybersecurity at RSA, Black Hat, and DEF CON. He went through YC in W23 and has since coached founders into the batch.

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